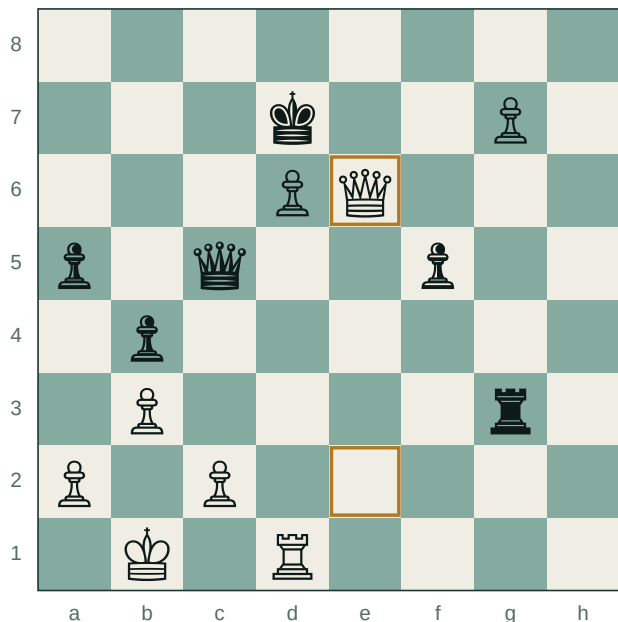


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 39

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 39.Qxe6+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...Kxe6 40. d7 Rg2 41. g8=B+ Rxcg8

39...Kxe6 The king captures the queen on e6. Recorded reply: **40.d7**.

40...Rg2 The rook moves from g3 to g2. Recorded reply: **41.g8=B+**.

41...Rxcg8 The rook captures the bishop on g8.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +10. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +10**: the balance goes from -2 to +8. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on b1. Geometrically undefended: queen on e6 and rook on d1. Check for tactical protection.